

BROKILD APPS · VST3 INSTRUMENT

ESCAPE ROOM

A noise machine that will not tell you what its knobs do.



User Manual

Quick start · Reference · Try this

Version 1.0

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Escape Room is a noise machine built as a puzzle. Five sound cells, a playable resonant door, three traps, and a six-bit lock that decides — invisibly, but never randomly — what everything in the room does to everything else.

Most synthesisers are laid out so you can predict them. This one is laid out so you have to *learn* it. The knobs are marked **MASS**, **ALEPH** and **BETH**; the cells are called SKRA, VELM, ONDA, KRYS and GORR; and none of that tells you anything on the first day.

What makes it worth the trouble is the **SIGIL**. It is a number from 0 to 63, shown as six lamps on the lock. Each sigil seeds eight wires: each wire listens to something in the room and moves something else. Sigil 41 always builds the same eight wires — on your machine, on mine, tomorrow, next year. So the machine is baffling, but it is not random, and anything you stumble into can be found again.

The five things to know before you touch anything

It makes sound on its own	Load it and it is already running. MIDI notes are not required — they tune the resonant filter rather than start the sound.
BIND is the master mystery knob	At zero, the wires do nothing and every control does exactly what it says. Turn it up and the room starts moving itself.
The lock is repeatable	Sixty-four rooms, each one fixed. The KART in the bottom right remembers which ones you have visited.
There is a limiter	Permanently, after everything. There are three feedback paths in here and they can all be opened at once.
There is a legend	Hidden. Section 09 tells you where — but you may prefer to find it yourself.

Escape hatch. The red  button at the top right empties every feedback store in the room instantly. Nothing is lost except the ringing. Use it freely.

What is in the box

- **Escape Room.vst3** — 64-bit Windows VST3 instrument, MIDI in, stereo out.
- **Escape Room.exe** — the same instrument as a standalone application, if you want to play with it without opening a DAW.
- This manual.

Do these six things in order and you will have heard everything the machine can do, without needing to know what anything is called.

1 Load it and listen.

Put Escape Room on a MIDI instrument track. It starts making sound immediately — a wash with clicks in it. Nothing needs playing.

2 Play some notes.

Use your keyboard, your MIDI controller, or the scratched key strip at the bottom of the panel. The noise snaps into pitch: you are playing a resonant filter, four voices of it, so chords work.

3 Turn BIND all the way down.

Bottom of the middle panel, left knob. The room goes still. This is the honest state: every knob now does one thing and only that thing. Move a few and hear what they are.

4 Turn BIND back up to about two-thirds.

The room starts modulating itself along the eight wires drawn in the diagram above the knob. Watch the sparks: they run from source to destination, and the dotted arcs outside the knobs show you exactly where the room has pushed each one.

5 Change the sigil.

Click any of the six lamps on the lock, or drag the big number, or click a square in the **KART**. The eight wires are rebuilt instantly and the machine becomes a different animal. Sixty-four of them.

6 Press the dice.

Third button, top right. It shuffles the whole room. Press the arrow next to it to put it back. This is the fastest way to find something you would never have dialled up on purpose.



The whole room. Five cells down the left, the lock in the middle, the door on the right; traps, output, oracle along the bottom; keys and the map of sixty-four sigils underneath.

Left column — five cells

The sound sources. Each is a different species of noise; none of them is an ordinary oscillator. Each has a rocker (open / sealed), a **MASS** level and two unmarked knobs, **ALEPH** and **BETH**.

SEGL — the lock

Six bit-lamps, the sigil number, the wiring diagram, and the three knobs that decide how hard the room moves itself: BIND, DRIFT, PULSE.

PORT — the door

The playable four-voice resonant filter, the peephole oscilloscope, and the filter shape.

SKIRV • **DRAUP** • **MJØL**

The three traps: a slice repeater, a delay, a reverb.

UTVEI

Saturation, output level, master meter, and the CLAMP lamp that lights when the limiter is holding the door shut.

ORAKEL

The terminal. It reports the wiring, and it tells you the real value of any knob while you are dragging it.

TANGENT

Three octaves of keys, C2 to C5. Playable with the mouse and lit by incoming MIDI.

KART

Sixty-four squares, one per sigil. Dim means never visited, warm means visited, bright means you are in it. Click to travel.

Reading a knob

A knob shows its own position as a solid arc. When the loom is pushing it, a **dotted ghost arc** appears just outside, spanning from where you set it to where the room has actually put it. That is the single most useful thing on the panel: it is how you see modulation rather than guess at it.

Drag a knob and the **ORAKEL** prints its real value in real units — hertz, milliseconds, per cent. Hold **Shift** while dragging for fine control, double-click to reset to default, and the scroll wheel nudges.



One cell: roman numeral and glyph, the rocker with its lamp, MASS / ALEPH / BETH, and an activity meter. A sealed cell dims and its meter falls to nothing.



All five cells. Sealed cells dim and their meters fall away — cell II and cell V are sealed by default.

Each cell makes noise a different way. ALEPH and BETH mean something different in every one of them — that is deliberate, and it is the main thing there is to learn about the machine.

I • SKRA — the geiger cloud

Random impulses. Each one is a short pitched click with a random polarity, a random pan and a randomised pitch around the setting.

ALEPH How often it ticks, from a third of a click a second to 2600 a second. Low is a crackle; high is a hiss with grain in it.

BETH The size and pitch of each tick, from 0.5 ms at 7.5 kHz down to 160 ms at 110 Hz. Low is dust; high is a bag of dropped marbles.

The hidden coupling. SKRA also strikes the strings in **KRYS** — whether or not SKRA itself is switched on. If cell IV is ringing and you cannot find out why, this is why.

II • VELM — the cross-modulated pair

Two sine oscillators, each modulating the other's frequency. Below about 60 % this is a metallic FM tone. Above it, the pair stops being periodic and starts screaming.

ALEPH	Pitch and ratio at the same time — 17 Hz to 2.8 kHz, with the second oscillator's ratio widening as you go up. One knob, two jobs.
BETH	The modulation depth. This is the knob that decides whether the cell is an instrument or an emergency.

III • ONDA — the wandering formants

Pink noise through three resonant band-passes at an inharmonic spacing, whose centres take a random walk. The most "musical" cell, and the one to leave on while learning the door.

ALEPH	Where the three bands sit, 65 Hz to 6 kHz.
BETH	Two things at once: how tight the bands are (Q 2 to 46) and how fast they roam (0.05 to 9 Hz). Low is a slow wide wash; high is a chattering swarm.

IV • KRYS — the string bank

Five delay lines tuned to an inharmonic series — bell-like rather than harmonic — struck by an internal spark and by SKRA.

ALEPH	Tuning, 42 Hz to 1.7 kHz for the lowest string.
BETH	Decay and brightness together, from a short damped tick to a ring that lasts most of a minute. High settings also strike less often, because they do not need to.

V • GORR — the maw

The strange one. GORR does not generate anything; it eats the room's own output — everything, after the door — and destroys it: sample-rate crusher, then bit crusher, then a wavefolder. What comes out goes back into the room. This is the feedback loop, and it is the reason the machine can surprise you.

ALEPH	Destruction. Sample rate divided by up to 111, bit depth from 15 down to just over 1.
BETH	Fold amount, <i>and</i> how much of the room GORR is fed. Turning this up tightens the feedback loop; at the top the room is howling at itself.

If it is stuck howling — press , or pull GORR's BETH down, or seal the cell. The limiter will keep it from being dangerous, but it will not make it stop.

Everything the cells make passes through the door. It is a state-variable filter that can be driven to a very high Q, it has four independently played voices, and it is where noise becomes music.



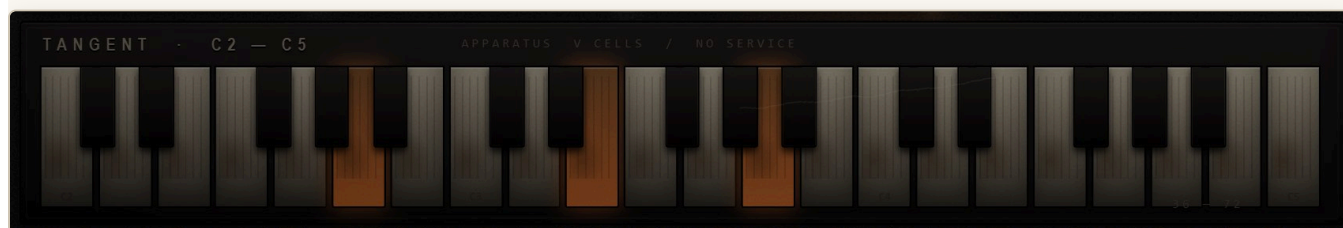
The peephole: an oscilloscope of the output, drawn on tired phosphor.

Playing it

A MIDI note does not start a sound — the room is already making sound. A note opens a filter voice tuned to that note, with its own envelope. Four notes can be held; a fifth steals the oldest voice.

WHEEL	Cutoff, 25 Hz to 16 kHz. With TRACK at 100 % the played notes own the pitch and this only sets the untriggered drone; below 100 % it blends back in.
TEETH	Resonance, Q 0.55 to 58. Above about 90 % the filter sings on its own and the cells become an excitation rather than a sound.
SHAPE	Low, band, high or notch. Band is the default and the most musical for noise; notch is the one to reach for when you want a hole rather than a note.
TRACK	Key follow. At 100 % a played note is exactly in tune. At 0 % the notes still open the envelope but the pitch stays where WHEEL puts it. Halfway is a squelch that only half agrees with you.
CREEP	Portamento between notes, up to 1.6 seconds.
ONSET / LETGO	Attack and release of the voice envelope: 0.8 ms to 4 s, and 4 ms to 8 s.
RESIDUE	The level of the untriggered drone — a fifth filter that is always open at WHEEL's frequency. At zero the instrument is silent until you play it; at maximum it drones under everything.
SWEEP	Envelope to cutoff. Below 50 % the envelope sweeps down, above it sweeps up, by as much as three octaves at the extremes.
TWIN	A second resonance, 0 to 24 semitones above the first. At zero it is shut. A fifth or an octave turns single notes into intervals.
TWIN·M	How much of the twin is mixed in.

To make it sound tuned: TRACK 100 %, TEETH above 75 %, SHAPE on band, and one broadband cell open — ONDA is the easiest. Then play. To make it sound like a machine that has been left running for forty years, do the same with RESIDUE up and BIND at two-thirds.

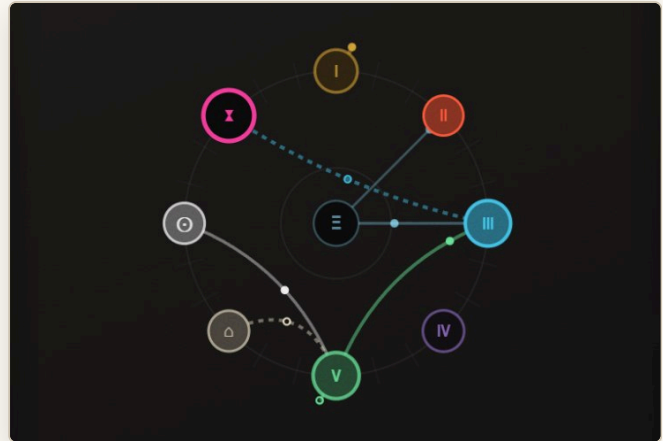


TANGENT: three octaves, C2 to C5. Keys light for mouse clicks and for incoming MIDI alike.

The four lamps

The row of small lamps under the shape buttons is the four voices. They light with the envelope, and the frequencies of everything currently sounding are printed to their right in hertz. Keys on the strip below light for both mouse and MIDI notes.

This is the part of the instrument that is actually unusual. Everything else is a good noise machine; the lock is what makes it a room you can get lost in.



Nine nodes: five cells, the door, the traps, the exit, and the chaos core in the middle. Arcs are wires; sparks run the way the signal runs.

How a sigil becomes a machine

The sigil is six bits — sixty-four values. That number seeds a small deterministic generator which strings **eight wires**. Each wire has:

- a **source**: one of twelve things it can listen to,
- a **destination**: one of twenty-one knobs it can move,
- a **depth** and a **sign** — it either raises or lowers,
- a **curve**: straight, squared, or stepped, which is why two wires with the same source and destination still do not feel alike.

The first four wires always land on a cell parameter, so no sigil is completely inert. The other four can go anywhere — the door's cutoff and resonance, the traps, the output drive, or a cell's level.

What a wire can listen to

I – V	The loudness of each cell. A sealed cell contributes nothing, so the rocker switches are also modulation switches.
ξ ψ ζ	The three axes of a Rössler attractor — a chaotic oscillator that never repeats and never runs away. PULSE sets its speed.
△	The door's envelope: how hard you are playing.
~ ≈	Two slow drunken walks.
⊙	The output level, which closes the biggest loop of all.

The three knobs

BIND	How hard every wire pulls. At zero the room is inert and every knob does exactly what it says. This is the setting to learn on.
DRIFT	A slow random walk added to every destination, wired or not. Even a completely unwired room will not sit still with this up.
PULSE	The speed of the chaos core and of the drift, 0.03 Hz to 5 Hz.

Reading the diagram

A **solid** arc with a filled spark pushes its destination up. A **dashed** arc with a hollow spark pulls it down. The colour of the arc tells you which node it comes from. A node swells while it is being moved, and glows while it is making sound. Wires whose source and destination are the same node loop back on themselves — those are the self-feeding ones, and they are usually the most interesting.

The map remembers. Every sigil you visit lights a square in the **KART** and the counter at the top counts them. It is kept between sessions. Sixty-four is the whole instrument.

Three effects, in this order, after the door. Each one has fewer knobs than it needs — the knobs it has do more than one thing.



SKIRV — the slice repeater

CHANCE Both the odds that any given slice gets caught and repeated, *and* how much of the repeat you hear. At zero it is off; at maximum the original is almost entirely replaced.

SHARD The slice length, 18 ms to 450 ms. Short is a granular buzz; long is a bar-length stutter.

A caught slice plays forward, backward, at double speed or at half speed, chosen at random. You do not get to pick.

DRAUP — the delay

DEPTH Delay time, 7 ms to 1.9 s, with a slow tape warble on the tap and a cross-fed ping-pong between the channels.

RETURN Feedback *and* wet level in one knob. Below about half it is a delay; above it, the loop starts to sustain; at the top it is a resonator.

GRAIN Tilts the tone inside the loop — dark and thick at the bottom, thin and papery at the top.

MJØL — the reverb

SPACE Size and tail together, 0.35 s to 16 s, getting darker as it gets bigger.

VEIL Dry / wet mix.

ASCENT Feeds an octave-up shimmer back into the reverb. A little is a halo; a lot climbs forever.

UTVEI — the way out



GABB

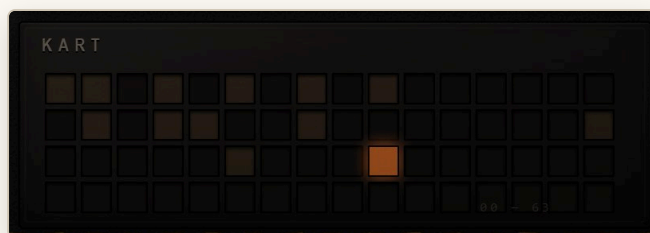
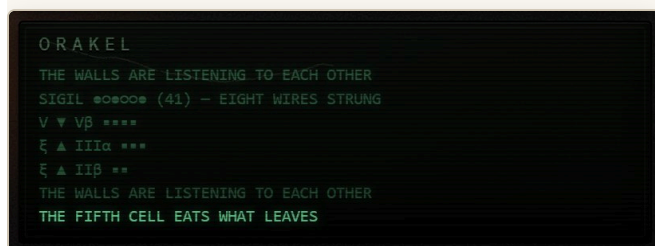
Saturation before the output, level-compensated so it thickens rather than simply gets louder.

UTVEI

Output level.

CLAMP

Not a control. The lamp lights when the limiter is holding the output down. Some of the best settings in this instrument live with it lit.



ORAKEL

The terminal is the only place in the instrument that speaks plainly, and it only does it when asked. It prints:

- the **real value** of any knob while you are dragging it, in real units — this is how you find out what a knob actually is;
- the sigil and the first three of its eight wires, whenever the lock changes;
- the state of a cell rocker or the door shape when you change it;
- occasional remarks. Some of them are hints.

KART

Sixty-four squares, one per sigil, laid out 16 across. Dark means you have never been there, warm means you have, and the bright one is where you are. Click any square to travel there. The counter at the top of the panel reads **ROOMS n/64**.

The keyhole

There is a legend — a full plain-English decoding of every mark on the panel, plus this room's eight wires written out in words. It is not on a menu.

Tap the keyhole three times. There is one at the foot of the door, and the small glowing one at the top right of the panel does the same thing. Once found it stays found, and either keyhole opens it from then on.

THE LEGEND

WHAT THE MARKS MEAN. YOU FOUND IT, SO YOU MAY KEEP IT.

SHUT

THE FIVE CELLS

SKRA – a geiger cloud. ALEPH is how often it ticks (0.3 → 2600 a second), BETH the size and pitch of each tick.

VELM – two sines modulating each other's frequency. ALEPH is pitch and ratio at once, BETH the depth. Past about 60 % it stops being periodic at all.

ONDA – pink noise through three band-passes that wander. ALEPH is where they sit, BETH how tight they are and how fast they roam.

KRYS – five inharmonic strings. ALEPH tunes them, BETH is decay, up to nearly forever. They are struck by SKRA whether or not SKRA is switched on.

GORR – eats the room's own output: sample-rate crusher, bit crusher, wavefolder. ALEPH destroys, BETH folds and decides how much of the room it is fed. This is the feedback loop; it is why the machine can surprise you.

PORT – the door

A resonant filter with four voices, played over MIDI or from the keys.

WHEEL cutoff · **TEETH** resonance, it sings above ~90 % · **SHAPE** low / band / high / notch · **TRACK** how much a played note owns the pitch – at 100 % it is in tune, at 0 the notes only open the envelope · **CREEP** portamento · **ONSET** / **LETGO** the envelope · **RESIDUE** the untriggered drone that is always open · **SWEEP** envelope to cutoff, downward below 50 % and upward above · **TWIN** a second resonance 0–24 semitones up, **TWIN-M** its level.

THE TRAPS

SKIRV – slice repeater. CHANCE is odds and mix in one, SHARD is the slice. It reverses and double-speeds at random.

DRAUP – delay. DEPTH is time, RETURN is feedback and level in one knob, GRAIN tilts the tone inside the loop.

MJØL – a four-line reverb. SPACE is size and tail, VEIL is mix, ASCENT feeds an octave-up shimmer back in.

GABB saturates, **UTVEI** is the output. A limiter sits after both – it has to.

SEGL – the lock

Six bits, sixty-four rooms. The sigil seeds eight wires; each listens to something and moves something else. The same sigil always builds the same eight wires, so a room you liked can be found again. The KART below remembers which ones you have been in.

BIND is how hard the wires pull. At zero the room is inert and every knob does exactly what it says – that is the way to learn it.

DRIFT adds a slow drunk walk to everything, wired or not.

PULSE is the speed of the chaos core and of the drift.

READING THE LOOM

A **solid** arc with a filled spark pushes its destination up; a **dashed** arc with a hollow spark pulls it down. The colour is the source. A ring node swells while it is being moved and glows while it is making sound. The dotted ghost arc outside a knob is where the loom has actually put that knob this instant.

SOURCES

I-V the loudness of each cell · $\xi \psi \zeta$ the three axes of a Rössler attractor · $\diamond$ the door's envelope · $\sim$ ≈ two drunk walks · $\odot$ the output level.

THIS ROOM'S EIGHT WIRES – SIGIL 41

cell V loudness lowers fold & room feed (73%, stepped)
chaos X raises formant centre (49%, squared)
chaos X raises cross-FM depth (38%, squared)
cell V loudness raises width & roam rate (75%, stepped)
cell I loudness raises tick size & pitch (55%, stepped)
output level raises fold & room feed (62%, straight)
door envelope lowers crush amount (72%, stepped)
cell III loudness lowers delay time (80%, straight)

The legend, once found. The block at the bottom is generated from the sigil you are actually in — it changes as you travel.

Sixty-four rooms is a lot to hold in your head. This is the routine that works.

1 Go inert.

BIND to zero, DRIFT to zero. Now the room is just five noise sources, a filter and three effects, and everything is honest.

2 Seal everything but one cell.

Learn ALEPH and BETH on that one cell with the ORAKEL open. Two knobs, five minutes. Then move on.

3 Find a sound you like

with the cells and the door only, traps at zero.

4 Now open BIND slowly.

Watch which knobs grow ghost arcs. Those are this sigil's destinations, and they are the same every time you come back to it.

5 Write the number down

— or just let the KART remember it. A sigil plus the knob positions is the whole patch; your DAW saves both.

6 When you are stuck, press the dice.

Then press the arrow if it was a mistake. Most rooms are found this way rather than reasoned into.

Three things that are not obvious

- **Sealing a cell also unplugs it from the loom.** Its loudness is a modulation source, so the rocker is a modulation switch as well as a mute.
- **KRYS is struck by SKRA even when SKRA is sealed.** Cell IV can be alive with cell I silent.
- **GORR closes a loop through the door.** Its character therefore depends on TEETH, on SHAPE, and on what you are playing. The same GORR setting is a different effect in every room.

Starting points. All of them assume you have pressed the escape hatch first, and all of them want you to move on quickly.

Playable rust organ

ONDA only, MASS **60**. BIND **0**. TEETH **84**, SHAPE **band**, TRACK **100**, RESIDUE **0**, ONSET **25**, LETGO **55**. TWIN **29** (a fifth), TWIN-M **50**. MJØL VEIL **35**.

Chords out of noise. The cleanest thing this instrument does.

The room eats itself

GORR open, MASS **35**, ALEPH **60**, BETH **70**. TEETH **88**. Any one other cell at MASS **25** to feed it. GABB **35**.

A feedback instrument. Play notes to steer the howl; the CLAMP lamp will be lit and that is fine.

The geiger counter

SKRA only, ALEPH **15**, BETH **20**. RESIDUE **80**, TEETH **92**, WHEEL **30**. DRAUP DEPTH **18**, RETURN **55**.

Sparse ticks that each ring the filter. Play a slow melody over it.

Insect weather

VELM ALEPH **70**, BETH **72**. ONDA BETH **85**. BIND **80**, DRIFT **35**, PULSE **62**. Sigil **41**.

Nothing is stable. Leave it running and come back in a minute.

Bell mine

SKRA ALEPH **44** and **sealed**; KRYs open, ALEPH **28**, BETH **88**, MASS **55**. MJØL SPACE **75**, VEIL **45**, ASCENT **30**.

Sealed cell I is still striking the strings. Nothing on the panel says so.

Cathedral of dropped marbles

SKRA ALEPH **62**, BETH **80**. MJØL SPACE **92**, VEIL **60**, ASCENT **55**. TEETH **40**, SHAPE **low**.

Enormous, slow, and climbing. Good under everything.

Something is wrong with the tape

ONDA + KRYs. SKIRV CHANCE **45**, SHARD **22**. DRAUP DEPTH **60**, RETURN **48**, GRAIN **25**. BIND **50**, PULSE **20**.

Glitching, warbling, and never twice the same.

Sixty-four doors

Any patch you like. BIND **65**. Now walk the KART, one square at a time, and give each one ten seconds.

This is the instrument's real use. Half of them will be wrong and three of them will be yours.

Controls, in the order the host lists them

PARAMETER	RANGE	WHAT IT IS
CELL <i>n</i> · OPEN	sealed / open	Cell on. Also unplugs the cell from the loom.
CELL <i>n</i> · MASS	0 – 100	Cell level into the room.
CELL <i>n</i> · ALEPH	0 – 100	First character knob — see section 04.
CELL <i>n</i> · BETH	0 – 100	Second character knob — see section 04.
DOOR · WHEEL	25 Hz – 16 kHz	Cutoff.
DOOR · TEETH	Q 0.55 – 58	Resonance.
DOOR · SHAPE	low / band / high / notch	Filter response.
DOOR · TRACK	0 – 100	Key follow.
DOOR · CREEP	0.8 ms – 1.6 s	Portamento.
DOOR · ONSET	0.8 ms – 4 s	Envelope attack.
DOOR · LETGO	4 ms – 8 s	Envelope release.
DOOR · RESIDUE	0 – 100	Untriggered drone level.
DOOR · SWEEP	0 – 100	Envelope to cutoff, ±3 octaves about 50.
DOOR · TWIN	0 – 24 semitones	Second resonance interval; 0 is shut.
DOOR · TWIN MASS	0 – 100	Twin level.
SIGIL	0 – 63	The lock. Rebuilds all eight wires.
LOOM · BIND	0 – 100	Wire depth. Zero is inert.
LOOM · DRIFT	0 – 100	Slow random walk on every destination.
LOOM · PULSE	0.03 – 5 Hz	Chaos and drift speed.
TRAP Ⅹ · CHANCE	0 – 100	Stutter probability and mix.
TRAP Ⅹ · SHARD	18 – 450 ms	Slice length.
TRAP ∞ · DEPTH	7 ms – 1.9 s	Delay time.
TRAP ∞ · RETURN	0 – 100	Feedback and wet level.
TRAP ∞ · GRAIN	0 – 100	Tone tilt inside the loop.
TRAP ☙ · SPACE	0.35 – 16 s	Reverb size and tail.
TRAP ☙ · VEIL	0 – 100	Reverb mix.
TRAP ☙ · ASCENT	0 – 100	Octave-up shimmer into the tail.
MOUTH	0 – 100	Saturation (marked GABB on the panel).

EXIT	0 – 100	Output level (marked UTVEI).
Forty-five parameters in all, every one automatable. The host shows real units for the ones that have them and a rune plus a percentage for the ones that do not — the panel keeps its secrets, but your automation lane does not have to.		
Mouse and keyboard		
Drag a knob	Change it. The ORAKEL shows the real value.	
Shift-drag	Fine.	
Double-click	Back to default.	
Scroll wheel	Nudge.	
Drag the sigil number	Scroll through all sixty-four.	
Computer keys	Z S X D C V G B H N J M and Q 2 W 3 E R 5 T 6 Y 7 U play two octaves from C3.	
Escape	Shuts the legend.	



The header: wordmark, the count of rooms visited, the build number, and the four buttons — keyhole, undo, dice, escape.

The buttons in the header

ENCODE	Writes this patch to a file. See below.
DECODE	Reads one back in.
red	Empties every feedback store. Parameters are untouched.
dice	Shuffles the whole room, sigil included.
arrow	Undoes the last shuffle.
keyhole	See section 08.

ENCODE and DECODE

A patch is the forty-five numbers and nothing else, so it is a small readable file rather than a blob. **ENCODE** puts an ordinary Save dialog in front of you, opened on the patch folder and already suggesting the room you are in — `Room 41.json`. **DECODE** opens the folder as a menu.



Sub-folders fly out sideways and sit beside the loose patches. **BROWSE...** reaches anywhere on disk; **PATCH FOLDER...** moves the whole library, and the plugin remembers where it went.

Where they go	A folder called User presets beside the installed <code>.vst3</code> , so the library travels with the plugin. Where that cannot be written to, <code>Documents\Escape Room Patches</code> is used instead. Encoding a patch somewhere else moves the library there from then on — though not when you simply file one in a sub-folder of the library it already has.
What is in one	Every parameter, sigil included, plus the build that wrote it. Plain JSON: you can read it, diff it, or mail someone a room.
What is not	The KART's memory of which rooms you have been in, and whether you have found the legend. Those live on the machine rather than in a patch, because they are about you rather than about the sound.

Saving in a project

All forty-five parameters are stored in the DAW's session and in the host's own preset system as well, so reopening a project restores the room without touching the patch folder at all. The folder is for the rooms you want to reach for again; the project looks after itself.

Every Brokild synth carries the same rack. Not a copy of it and not a similar one: the identical set of effects and characters, compiled into each instrument and saved inside each patch. Learn it here and you have learned it in all of them.

The globe on the panel opens it. What appears is two racks side by side — **effects** on the left, **characters** on the right — and they do very different things. An effect processes what the synth has already made. A character reaches back into the instrument and changes how it makes it.



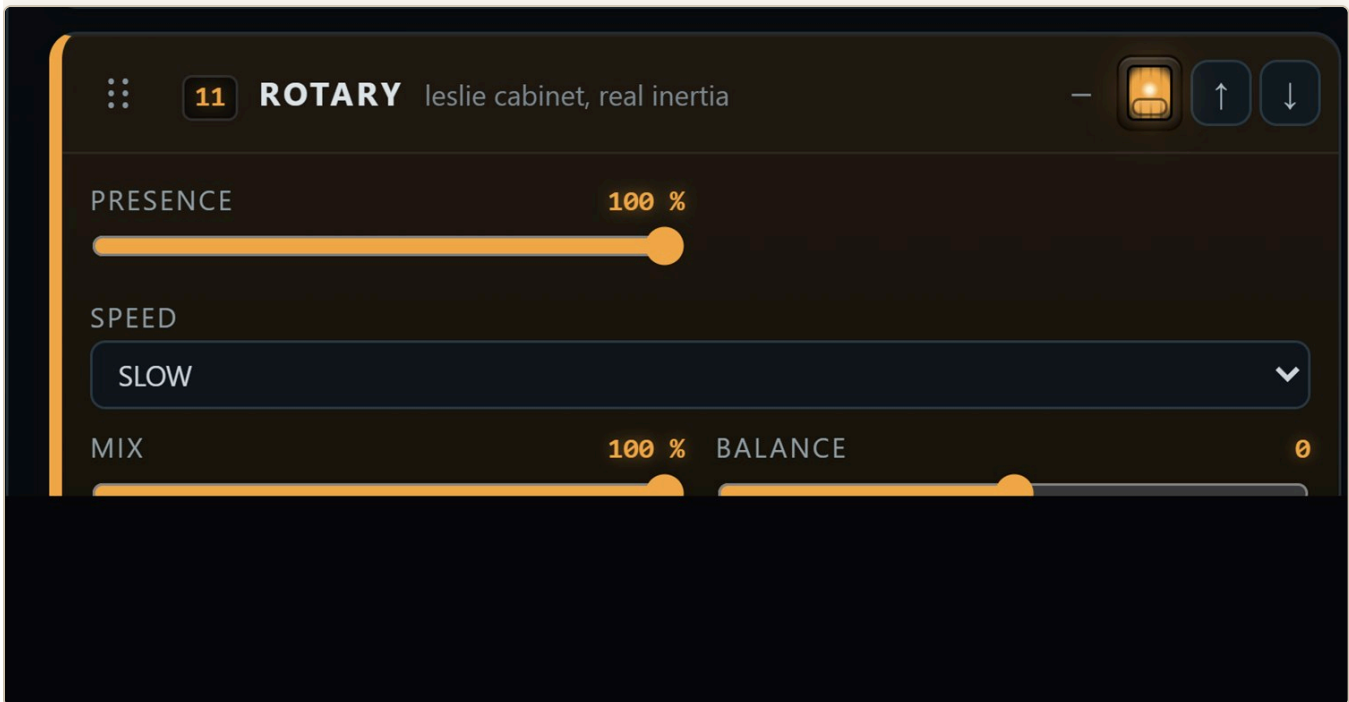
The world rack. Twelve effect pedals on the left, six characters on the right, and one **RACK MIX** over the lot. Here **TUBE**, **ECHO**, **SPACE** and **ROTARY** are lit, with **GLASS CATHEDRAL** and **TAPE SEANCE** holding the instrument.

Nothing is on when you start, and an empty rack is not a bypass — it is an absence. The audio never enters it. A patch you made before the rack existed sounds exactly as it did, to the sample, and the plugin's own test bench checks that on every build.

The pedals

Twelve, in the order they run: **TUBE** (asymmetric valve saturation, and its **DRIVE** holds its level as you turn it up, so the pedal gets dirtier rather than louder), **SWEEP** (four-stage phaser), **ENSEMBLE** (dual-line chorus), **HARMONIC** (the brownface split-band tremolo, plus plain tremolo and true vibrato), **GATE** (rhythmic

stutter), **GRIT** (crusher and dirt), **STRIP** (compressor and five-band EQ), **ECHO** (stereo tape echo up to five seconds), **SPACE** (true convolution reverb), **SHIMMER** (a feedback network with the octave folded back into the loop), **ROTARY** (a Leslie with real inertia — the horn takes about a second to change its mind, the drum about four) and **KIERANATOR** (the step glitcher). ECHO, GATE and HARMONIC lock to the host clock.



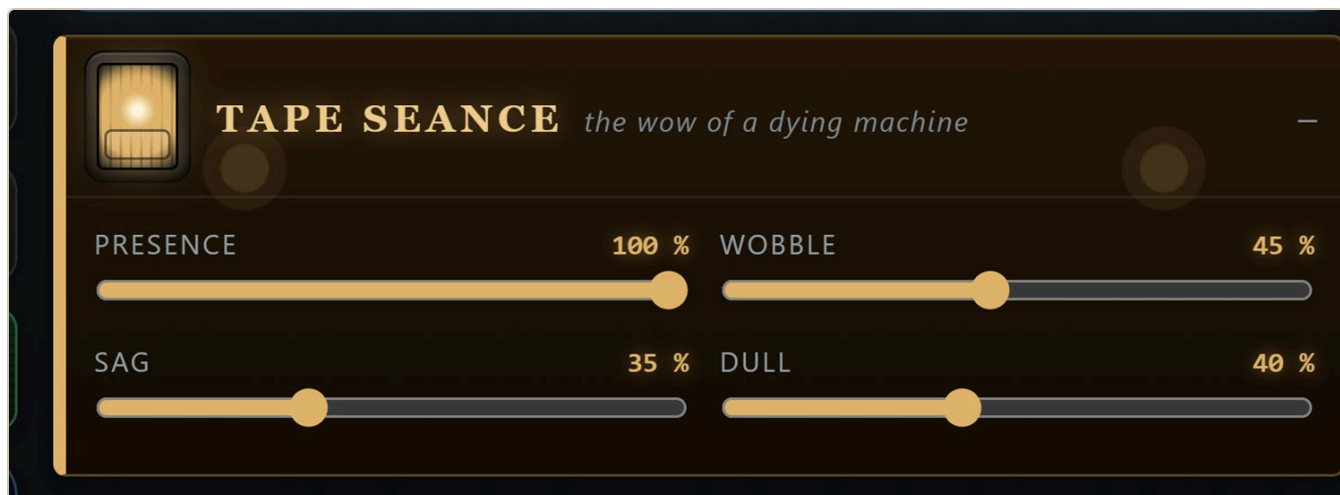
Every pedal carries one control it does not own itself: **PRESENCE**, in the rack's own colour. It is how much of that pedal is in the signal at all — at zero the pedal is inert and the audio passes it untouched.

Drag a pedal by its grip to reorder the chain, or use the arrows. Reordering while sound is playing is safe: the rack dips through the change and comes back on the other side.

The characters

The right-hand rack is **SPECTRA**, and it does not process the sound — it possesses the instrument. A character reaches into the voices themselves: how far they drift out of tune with each other, how wide they sit, whether they breathe, whether they sag flat as they die, how dark the filter runs. Two synths under the same character do not sound alike. They sound like themselves, haunted the same way.

DARK DRONE is a cluster gone dark, with a drift that takes minutes to come round. **PSYCHEDELIC PINK** breathes the width, tuning and filter over a wash of phaser, chorus and reverse reverb it carries itself. **INDUSTRIAL BLACK** is grind, chop and clang. **GLASS CATHEDRAL** is a hall of its own and a breath on the tuning. **TAPE SEANCE** is the wow of a dying machine. **INSECT SWARM** is sixteen wings, none of them agreeing.



A character opened. **PRESENCE** here is how hard it grips, so you can have a suggestion of one character and the full weight of another.

Characters stack: arm two and both take hold, in the order you armed them. Their pitch sag is keyed to each note's gate rather than its volume, so a held note stays in tune and only sinks as it dies. In the Escape Room the characters take the door itself. What they detune is the resonance you play, and a released voice sinks away flat — the room letting go of the note.

The step glitcher

KIERANATOR keeps the last ten seconds of everything the synth has played, and every one of its effects is a different way of reading that buffer back. Paint a bar of sixteen steps with the brushes — RETRIG, TAPE STOP, REVERSE, SHUFFLE, PITCH, CRUSH, GATE — and it plays the pattern against the host's bars. The same brush again clears a step. With no host transport it free-runs on its own clock. It is named for the late Kieran Foster, whose Glitch made this kind of thing worth doing.

What the rack remembers

The rack belongs to the patch. Save a patch and its rack goes with it; load one from before the rack existed and it comes back rack-empty, which is exactly the sound it promised. The **PRESETS** menu in the header holds ten made-up racks to start from. And because the rack is shared code, every Brokild synth gets new modules and fixes on its next build — the effects are the same effects, wherever you opened them.

Installing

1 Unzip.

Copy `Escape Room.vst3` — the whole folder — into `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\`. A sub-folder such as `...\VST3\Brokild\` is fine; hosts look inside.

2 Rescan.

Start your DAW and let it rescan plugins. Escape Room appears as an **instrument**, manufacturer Brokild.

3 Or just run it.

`Escape Room.exe` in the same zip is the standalone version; it needs no installation and picks its audio device from its own options menu.

If the panel does not appear — the interface is drawn in a WebView2 surface, which every up-to-date Windows 10 and 11 already has. If yours does not, install the free Microsoft Edge WebView2 Runtime and reopen the plugin. The instrument keeps making sound with the window shut either way.

Specifications

Format	VST3, 64-bit Windows. Standalone included.
Type	Instrument. MIDI in, stereo out, no audio input.
Voices	Four filter voices, last-note priority with oldest-voice stealing.
Parameters	45, all host-automatable.
Sample rates	Any. Tested 44.1, 48, 88.2 and 96 kHz.
Latency	None reported. Nothing in the signal path looks ahead.
Tail	Declared 8 seconds. MJØL can be considerably longer than that at full SPACE — leave room at the end of a bounce.
CPU	Modest and roughly constant. The reverb and the shimmer are the only parts that switch off when unused.

A word about levels

This is a noise machine with three feedback paths, and it is loud. A brick-wall limiter sits permanently after the output stage, so it cannot exceed full scale, but that is a safety device and not a mix decision — put it on a track with a fader like anything else, and watch the CLAMP lamp if you care about how hard it is working.

Escape Room — Brokild Apps. Build 260822.2, August 2026.

Native C++ audio, JUCE 8, interface drawn in the plugin's own window.

Free to use. No installer, no account, no telemetry, nothing phones home.